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After more than a year, CRPD calls plate readers 'pretty amazing'



Two SUVs were outfitted with the units last winter. The computerized cameras record and store license plate info and locations of passing vehicles. (Forrest Saunders/KCRG) (KCRG)

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Published: Sep. 2, 2017 at 4:08 AM UTC



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Cedar Rapids police are giving their automatic license plate readers rave reviews after installing them about a year and a half ago.

Two SUVs were outfitted with the units last winter. The computerized cameras record and store license plate info and locations of passing vehicles.

Though they don't identify the driver-- they will alert officers if the vehicle could be stolen or if records show a registered owner is wanted. The numbers suggest they're doing their job.

Since February 2016, the two sets of readers have scanned more than one million vehicles, they've helped find, 24 stolen vehicles, seven stolen plates, 48 wanted persons, two missing people.

CRPD is happy with the results, considering this was all accomplished by minimal staff that likely wouldn't have been able to do it without the cameras.

"We're talking about just two vehicles out there, so two to four officers have recovered that," said Sgt. Doug Doyle, who helps administrate the program. "It's pretty amazing. You become a little bit more responsive to everything else going on in the community and not paying as much attention

Each camera system can scan 7,000-8,000 plates during an eight-hour shift. That's a near impossibility for anyone else besides an automaton.

There are mistakes from time to time. The reader misread our station vehicle's plates adding an extra letter. Still, officials say they're well worth the investment about \$44,000 for the equipment, more than \$25,000 for the subscription. Money coming from grants and PD asset forfeiture.

"I think it's great," said Officer Randall Vest, who uses one of the two vehicles. "I think if we had more of an opportunity to have more of these on vehicles, it would be more beneficial to the public-- making the people safer."

And "more" could happen in the future. Police officials tell TV9 they will "continue to evaluate our program and are considering adding LPRs to additional vehicles as grants or other funding opportunities become available."

Not everyone is a fan of the readers. Some feel they're an invasion of privacy.

The ACLU of Iowa has released a statement recommending proper use of the systems.

"When used in a narrow and carefully regulated way, ALPRs can help police recover stolen cars and arrest people with outstanding warrants," said the group. "We believe there is a way to use ALPRs to promote public safety while also protecting citizens' civil liberties."

Some communities, like Iowa City, even have regulations forbidding their use. Iowa City police told TV9 in 2015 they had no interest in asking for license plate readers since a council ordinance specifically prohibits it.

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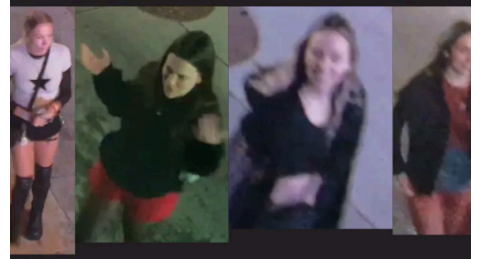
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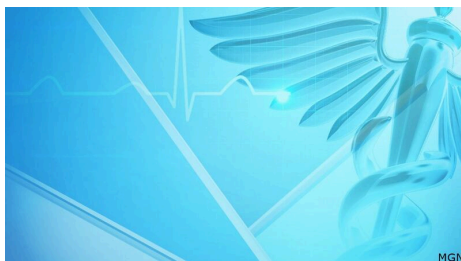
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